CM321 Final Research Paper

The Effects of TikTok on College Students' Modern-Day Consumption

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CM321
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December 12, 2023

Introduction

In the constantly evolving era of digital media, TikTok has emerged as a popular social media platform holding influence over the consumption habits of a span of generations. More specifically, the #TikTokMadeMeBuyIt hashtag is dominating trends and refers to TikTok users discovering new products through other users' product reviews and tutorials. This research paper explores the digital effects of TikTok on modern-day consumption, addressing the dynamics surrounding content oversaturation, user trends, and the viral power of influencer-driven commerce. The platform continues to redefine how individuals engage with content and make purchasing decisions, understanding the nuanced relationship between TikTok, consumer behavior, and digital trends.

Our research begins by studying TikTok's role in fostering an oversaturation of content and examining how the platform curates personalized feeds based on users' interactions with videos. The paper delves into the implications of this content oversaturation, exploring its correlation with users' attention spans and the subsequent impact on consumption patterns. By investigating trends at both micro and macro levels, we aim to unravel their effectiveness and the compelling appeal they play on consumers. From user screen time to promotions to advertisements on TikTok, we dissect the direct effects of influencer-driven trends on the sale of products, studying the relationship between online trends and consumer choices.

Building upon personal experiences and past research studies, we have come up with three hypotheses:

H1: TikTok users with high screen time will tend to display higher consumption behavior.

H2: TikTok users with higher positive attitudes toward social media promotions will exhibit higher consumption behaviors.

H3: TikTok users with high screen time will be shown more advertisements/promotions than those with lower screen time.

Together, these hypotheses contribute to the understanding of how screen time, advertisements, and social media lead to the increased consumption behavior seen today among college students. Further, it can be an explanation for TikTok's addictive nature and how businesses are changing the way they target consumers by increasing their spending habits through short-form videos.

Literature Review

1.1 Defining TikTok

TikTok is a social media application that was launched in 2016 by Zhang Yiming (Vaterlaus & Winter, 2021). Beijing Bytedance Technology purchased the application Musical.ly in November 2017 and was later renamed to TikTok (Montag, 2021). Upon launching, it has amassed over millions of users and has solidified its position as one of the top social media applications. In 2020 alone, TikTok had over 800 million monthly users (Montag, 2021). The TikTok application allows users to record and upload short-form videos. These videos can be shared, liked, reposted, and commented on by other users. Users can create their own content, while also interacting with endless videos created by other influencers and content creators.

The unique selling point of the app stems from its feed content. Videos on each user's feed are personally curated based on the user's preferences using what many call the algorithm. The algorithm of TikTok tracks the video content users interact with and subsequently continues to push similar content (Editors, 2022).

Similarly, TikTok allows users to make in-app purchases through their recently added eshop feature, TikTok shop. TikTok offers the “Fulfilled by TikTok” program for sellers which oversees and handles the entire logical side of the eshop for each seller (Korn, 2023). In the first quarter of 2023, TikTok generated over 680 million USD from in-app purchases (Ceci, 2023). It is important to note that 55% of TikTok users have made a purchase after seeing a brand on the app (West, 2023). Additionally, the engagement rate is 5.7%, which is 12 times more than the runner-up, Instagram (Lauron, 2023). As such, the influence that TikTok possesses as a social media application is quite evident. For the purpose of this study, we will focus on the application of TikTok in relation to its consumer effects, mainly in terms of consumption behavior.

1.2 Screen time

Screen time can be defined as the amount of time a person spends using social media platforms. As the popularization and advancement of technology continue, so does the rise of users' screen time and their relation to well-being. Many studies even tend to focus on the declining, negative effects it has on children’s physiological and psychological development (Domingues-Montanari, 2017). While screen time can vary, much of the data raises pressing issues in today’s society. In past studies, there has been difficulty measuring screen time across different platforms due to mixed findings and constant debate (K Kaye et al., 2020).

Recently, TikTok has been at the forefront of controversy pertaining to the amount of screen time users have on the application. With 2.6 billion downloads and over 100 million users, TikTok has newly implemented a screen time limit, where 13-17-year-olds have an automatic limit of one hour (TikTok, n.d.). Although this may seem like a positive step in the right direction, this new feature naively neglects the fact that a large number of users are not

minors. The application also fosters a very specific algorithmic structure. This means that users are recommended content based on other videos they have interacted with in the past. TikTok's algorithm is curated to foster a sense of serendipity and captivation with content that is specifically catered to the users' personal data, meaning their likes, dislikes, interests, and more. This makes it easier for TikTok to target the use of advertisements and promotions to those who interact with more trendy videos related to a shopping purchase.

1.3 Advertisements & Promotions

Advertising is a paid, mediated form of marketing communication from an identifiable source, designed to persuade the consumer to take some sort of action now or in the future, whereas promotions are a product of marketing including sales, public relations, and advertising. Together, we define them as the amount of content used to influence consumer behavior in purchasing or perceiving a brand in a certain desired way. Recently, with the rise of TikTok, there has been a surge in short-form video commerce. Short-form videos last anywhere from 15 seconds to three minutes. Users share interesting life experiences or tips and can like, comment, and share the videos posted by others. This new wave of social media has created a more convenient way for people to communicate and has led to the emergence of new forms of business models. Short-form video commerce, specifically, has become an emerging strategy for businesses to use as advertising (Xicheng et al., 2023). According to Business Insider, teens spend almost two hours on the app daily – over an hour difference in screen time than any other competing application (Tenore, 2023). Xiao, Li, and Zhang found that by December 2021, the number of short-video application users reached 934 million (Xiao et al., 2023). This shows the

powerful influence TikTok has on its users, both by time spent on the app and by the volume of viewership. Thus, we concluded that:

H3: TikTok users with high screen time will be shown more advertisements/promotions than those with lower screen time.

1.4 Advertisements and Engagement

Popularity in advertisements on social media has developed immensely in recent years. TikTok, a social media app with a significant impact on its audience, has become one of the most used apps to advertise or promote products, goods, and services.

Zuo and Wang declare that the platform is divided into three sectors; ordinary people, influencers, and brands (Zuo & Wang, 2019). The users who are classified as ordinary people use the platform to fulfill psychological needs by interacting with influencers and brands.

Studies show that TikTok is being dominated by Gen Z, 60% being women and 40% being men (Ortiz et al., (2023). With this target audience in mind, TikTok's business portal notes that 92% of users interact with brands, and users of this target audience also value brand image and expect to become knowledgeable about a product or service and their qualities before purchasing or supporting (Zuo & Wang 2019). It is worth noting that Gen-Z is a very aware generation. As such, marketers have shifted their efforts to alter the way they present ads and promotions, given their insights on consumption behavior and influencer perception (Pradhan et al., 2022).

Tiktok's aforementioned algorithm promotes an interactive platform where users can respond and interact with brands and influencers, furthering their interaction with the platform

and promotional content. The unique platform fosters a sense of community and connection amongst users, which in turn increases their engagement. According to Algesheimer, interaction can be defined as a force that influences consumer loyalty and, thus, the continuity of brand consumption (Ortiz et al., 2023). Essentially, the relationship that brands build with their consumers fuels their interaction, which in turn affects their consumption behavior. This new method of marketing and the rise of influencer marketing has been hugely influential on Gen Z's consumption behavior (Haenlein et al., 2020).

1.5 Consumption Behavior

Consumption behavior is the purchase and use of products and services in line with the needs of consumers (Avci, 2022). Along with this definition, comes the idea that consumption behavior is influenced by a variety of factors including psychological motivations, social interactions, cultural influences, economic means, and personal desires. In the world of social media, the channels of media used and the form the content is presented in play a critical role in determining whether one will go through with their purchase or not (Yogesh & Yesha, 2014). Social media applications use key algorithms and analytical tools to push out content related to the specific user, such as demographics, types of media consumed, and more. Consumers depend on their friends, influencers, and trusted online sources to navigate the virtual world of purchasing. Through a research study, "Exploring the TikTok Influences on Consumer Impulsive Purchase Behaviour," it was found that perceived usefulness was the key factor in influencing impulsive consumption behavior (Tee et al., 2023). This begs the question of what specific factors influence one's perception of usefulness and feasibility through the use of social media.

TikTok has grown significantly in numbers with over 800 million active users reported in 2020 (Tee et al., 2023). Users often embody herd behavior to make consumption choices based on influencers who are often viewed as idealized versions of themselves (Pellegrino, 2022). According to a recent statistic, 61% of TikTok users aged between 18 to 34 years old reported that an influencer affected their buying decisions (Russell, 2022). This, and many more factors, indicate that there is a strong positive relationship between TikTok and the consumption behaviors that arise from individuals using the application. This leads us to hypothesize that:

H1: TikTok users with high screen time will tend to display higher consumption behavior.

1.6 Attitudes toward Social Media Promotions

Attitudes toward social media platforms refer to consumers' perception toward brands using social media platforms to interact with them to increase product sales. With the rapid development of social media platforms in recent years, advertisers have shifted their focus to digital marketing, which involves the use of social media platforms for advertisement placement. Hence, it is important to examine consumers' attitudes toward social media promotions, which could potentially have a direct impact on the effectiveness of promotions.

In a recent study, "Factors Affecting Clothing Purchase Intention in Mobile Short Video App: Mediation of Perceived Value and Immersion Experience," it is clear that perceived value and immersion experience play a mediating role in the relationship between social media interactivity and purchase intention (Hewei, 2022). In another study, the researchers proved that consumer perception of social media advertising, viral marketing, and brand awareness positively impact purchase intent (Vianna et al., 2016). Therefore, it is hypothesized that:

H2: TikTok users with higher positive attitudes toward social media promotions will exhibit higher consumption behaviors.

1.7 Controversies over TikTok's Effects

The debate over whether or not the social media application TikTok has a direct effect on users is ongoing. While some scholars see no effect between TikTok and user's personal lives, others are quick to argue the application's direct impact on users. Multiple research studies have been conducted to test TikTok's effect on various aspects of a user's life, spanning from the level of addictiveness to familial ties to many more.

To understand the scope of discussion for this matter, it is important to refer to various studies. A recent study published in 2021 by four scholars studying the influence of TikTok usage on positive emotions and relationships found that TikTok did not affect positive emotions (Tang et al., 2021). However, some dispute this study and criticize it for its use of snowballing techniques for data collection, arguing the data's validity. Similarly, a study conducted in October 2023 found that TikTok does have an effect on emotions by investigating the effects of the app's addictiveness on Chinese users (Akhtar & Islam, 2023). The scholars of this paper found that TikTok addiction is indeed a very real phenomenon and it does in fact have an effect on user's social anxiety, conflict, and loneliness levels. Such conflicts between research studies show the discrepancy that exists between researchers and what they chose to study, as well as how they investigated their claims.

Thus, our team intends to continue to contribute to the research network on whether or not TikTok has direct effects on its users. Particularly, we will focus on TikTok effects on

consumption behavior. Our research will focus on two primary research questions we intend to better understand:

RQ1: How does an oversaturation of content affect people's motivations behind spending patterns?

RQ2: How does TikTok's addictive nature affect the way users perceive the content they absorb on the app?

To address these research questions we propose three hypotheses:

H1: TikTok users with high screen time will tend to display higher consumption behavior.

H2: TikTok users with higher positive attitudes toward social media promotions will exhibit higher consumption behaviors.

H3: TikTok users with high screen time will be shown more advertisements/promotions than those with lower screen time.

Methods

To investigate our hypothesis and research questions, we conducted an analytical survey in order to find out if TikTok users with high screen time will tend to display higher consumption behavior, TikTok users with higher positive attitudes toward social media promotions will exhibit higher consumption behaviors, and TikTok users with high screen time will be shown more advertisements/promotions than those with lower screen time. We used snowball sampling as our main method of data collection, as it proved to be the most convenient and successful method for our research setting. This significantly helped us ensure that we received an adequate amount of responses, as our survey had no official posting or funding. In order to avoid our own reflexivity

impacting our results, we executed a thorough process of conceptually and operationally defining each of our variables. This helped us remove any subconscious biases that could have skewed our results. As such, by clearly defining our operational definitions for each of our variables, we were able to avoid asking leading and double-barreled questions, as well as trying our best to eliminate response bias. As an extra measure, we included reverse coding to confirm the consistency in our participant's answers and worked to provide a good selection of answer options, primarily through the use of Likert's scales and ranges. Overall, we focused on transparency as our way of combating the effects of reflexivity. By openly acknowledging how we may be affecting our results, from data collection to data analysis, we were able to curate a survey that was rich in question diversity, as well as question focus.

The final survey was sent out on November 3, 2023, and survey answers were collected until the end of the month. We used several different screening questions before participants continued with the survey to ensure that participants were suitable for our study. Firstly, we wanted to target people who are young millennials or Generation Z. We also wanted to focus on active social media users, specifically on TikTok, as our research is focused on advertisements on TikTok. Lastly, we asked participants if they were attending college/university or attended college/university in the Boston area in order to know the influence of social media on peers in our area.

We focused on four main variables for our research: screen time, consumption behavior, attitudes toward social media promotions, and number of advertisements/promotions. We asked three questions regarding screen time. In one question, participants were instructed to indicate their level of agreement with the statement, "I spend a lot of time on TikTok," on a 5-point

Likert scale. In the other questions, participants were asked to list the number of hours they spend on TikTok and how long they think is a reasonable amount of time to spend on the app.

We asked four questions regarding consumption behavior. We asked participants to indicate their level of agreement with two statements on a 5-point Likert scale. This included: “How often do you purchase goods and services through advertisements/promotions of products on TikTok?” and “Do you use TikTok to discover new brands to purchase from?” We then asked people to number from 0 to 6 “In the last month, how many purchases have you made based on sponsored content from TikTok users?” We asked people to guess, “In the last month, about how much would you say you've spent on purchases promoted to you by TikTok users?” from a range of $0-300+.

We asked three questions regarding attitudes toward social media promotions. Participants were instructed to indicate their level of agreement, helpfulness, and feeling with three statements respectfully on a 5-point Likert scale. An example includes “How often do you look at the advertisements/promotions of products when using TikTok?”

We asked six questions regarding the number of advertisements/promotions. We asked participants to indicate the level of agreement/probability of three statements on a 5-Likert scale, such as, “I see ads/sponsorships on my TikTok fyp.” We also asked participants to scroll through their for you page and see how many ads they got from 0-5. Finally, we asked participants to select all categories of advertisements they see on TikTok and what is the most successful.

Results

In total, 139 responses were collected. Among those responses, 103 were complete and 36 were incomplete. The age of respondents ranged from 18-31 years old, with 20 being the

mode age (51 participants are aged 20). Additionally, 121 participants responded "Yes" to attending a college or university in the Boston area, whereas 13 did not (Figure 1). Other descriptive statistics include whether the participants know what TikTok is and whether the participants use TikTok (Figure 2).

How old are you (in number form)?

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid		4	2.9	2.9	2.9
	18	6	4.3	4.3	7.2
	19	25	18.0	18.0	25.2
	20	51	36.7	36.7	61.9
	21	39	28.1	28.1	89.9
	22	9	6.5	6.5	96.4
	23	4	2.9	2.9	99.3
	31	1	.7	.7	100.0
	Total	139	100.0	100.0	

Are you going to a college or university in Boston area?

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Yes	121	87.1	90.3	90.3
	No	13	9.4	9.7	100.0
	Total	134	96.4	100.0	
Missing	System	5	3.6		
Total		139	100.0		

Figure 1: Survey Screener Questions Results (Part 1)

Do you know what TikTok is?

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Yes	119	85.6	99.2	99.2
	No	1	.7	.8	100.0
	Total	120	86.3	100.0	
Missing	System	19	13.7		
Total		139	100.0		

Do you use TikTok?

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Yes	104	74.8	86.7	86.7
	Yes but barely	14	10.1	11.7	98.3
	No	2	1.4	1.7	100.0
	Total	120	86.3	100.0	
Missing	System	19	13.7		
Total		139	100.0		

Figure 2: Survey Screener Questions Results (Part 2)

We used linear regression and Pearson's r correlation to test all three hypotheses.

H1: TikTok users with high screen time will tend to display higher consumption behavior

Descriptive Statistics

	Mean	Std. Deviation	N
time_total	6.7414	2.04778	116
consume_total	17.6754	3.65914	114

Correlations

		time_total	consume_total
time_total	Pearson Correlation	1	.474**
	Sig. (2-tailed)		<.001
	Sum of Squares and Cross-products	482.241	401.561
	Covariance	4.193	3.554
	N	116	114
consume_total	Pearson Correlation	.474**	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	
	Sum of Squares and Cross-products	401.561	1512.991
	Covariance	3.554	13.389
	N	114	114

**. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Figure 3: Pearson's r Correlation of Screen Time and Consumption Behavior

Model Summary

R	R Square	Adjusted R Square	Std. Error of the Estimate
.474	.225	.218	3.236

The independent variable is time_total.

ANOVA

	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Regression	340.143	1	340.143	32.482	<.001
Residual	1172.848	112	10.472		
Total	1512.991	113			

The independent variable is time_total.

Coefficients

	Unstandardized Coefficients		Standardized Coefficients		
	B	Std. Error	Beta	t	Sig.
time_total	.847	.149	.474	5.699	<.001
(Constant)	11.939	1.051		11.359	<.001

Figure 4: Linear Regression of Screen Time and Consumption Behavior

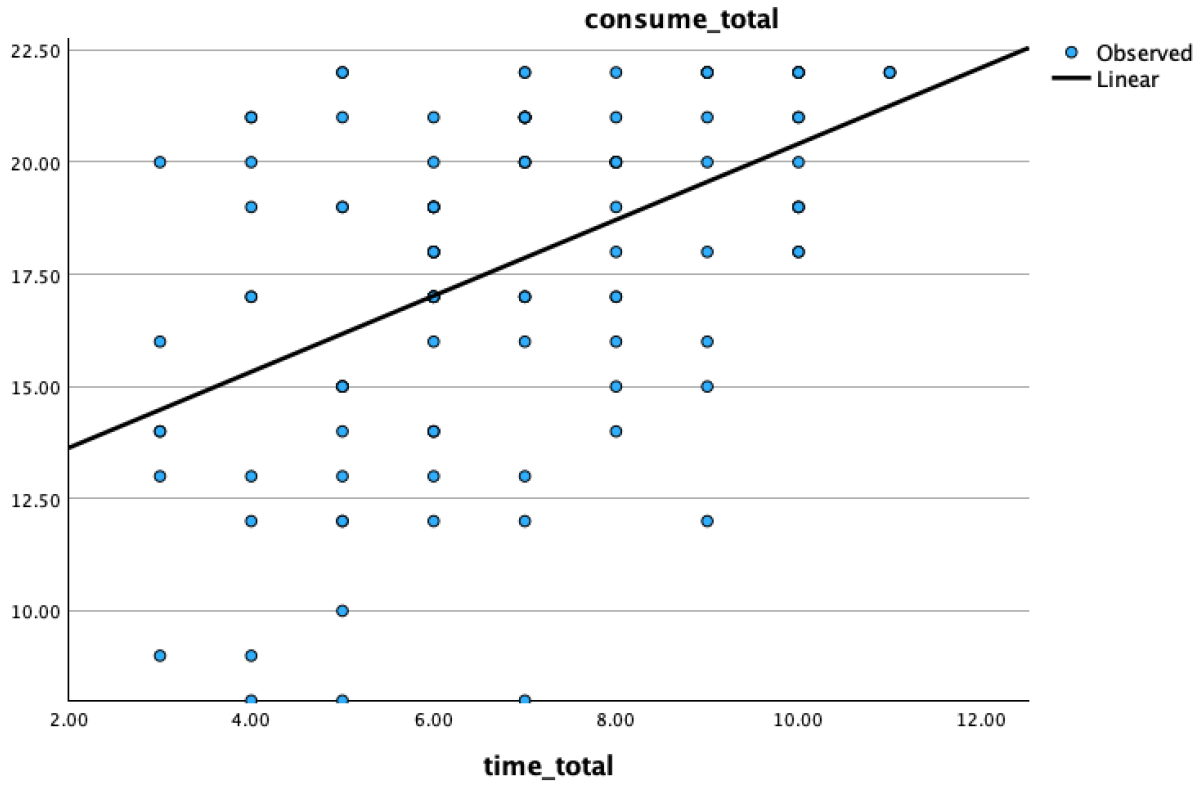


Figure 5: Scatter Plot Graph of Screen Time and Consumption Behavior

We found a moderate positive correlation between screen time on TikTok and consumption behavior, r (114) = .474, $p < .001$ (Figure 3). There is a strong line of regression between screen time and consumption behavior, $R^2 = .225$, $F(1, 113) = 32.482$, $p < .001$, which suggests that 22.5% of the variation in consumption behavior comes from screen time (Figure 4). The scatterplot graph of consumption behavior vs. screen time with the line of regression has a coefficient = .847, which means that when there is an increase in screen time on TikTok, it will result in a relatively similar amount of increase in the consumption behavior (Figure 5).

H2: TikTok users with higher positive attitudes toward social media promotions will exhibit higher consumption behaviors

Descriptive Statistics

	Mean	Std. Deviation	N
consume_total	17.6754	3.65914	114
attitude_total	8.2182	1.92226	110

Correlations

		consume_total	attitude_total
consume_total	Pearson Correlation	1	.368**
	Sig. (2-tailed)		<.001
	Sum of Squares and Cross-products	1512.991	286.073
	Covariance	13.389	2.625
	N	114	110
attitude_total	Pearson Correlation	.368**	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	
	Sum of Squares and Cross-products	286.073	402.764
	Covariance	2.625	3.695
	N	110	110

**. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Figure 6: Pearson's r Correlation of Attitude toward Social Media Promotions and Consumption Behavior

Model Summary

R	R Square	Adjusted R Square	Std. Error of the Estimate
.368	.136	.128	3.463

The independent variable is attitude_total.

ANOVA

	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Regression	203.190	1	203.190	16.941	<.001
Residual	1295.364	108	11.994		
Total	1498.555	109			

The independent variable is attitude_total.

Coefficients

	Unstandardized Coefficients		Standardized Coefficients		
	B	Std. Error	Beta	t	Sig.
attitude_total	.710	.173	.368	4.116	<.001
(Constant)	11.826	1.456		8.122	<.001

Figure 7: Linear Regression of Attitude toward Social Media Promotions and Consumption Behavior

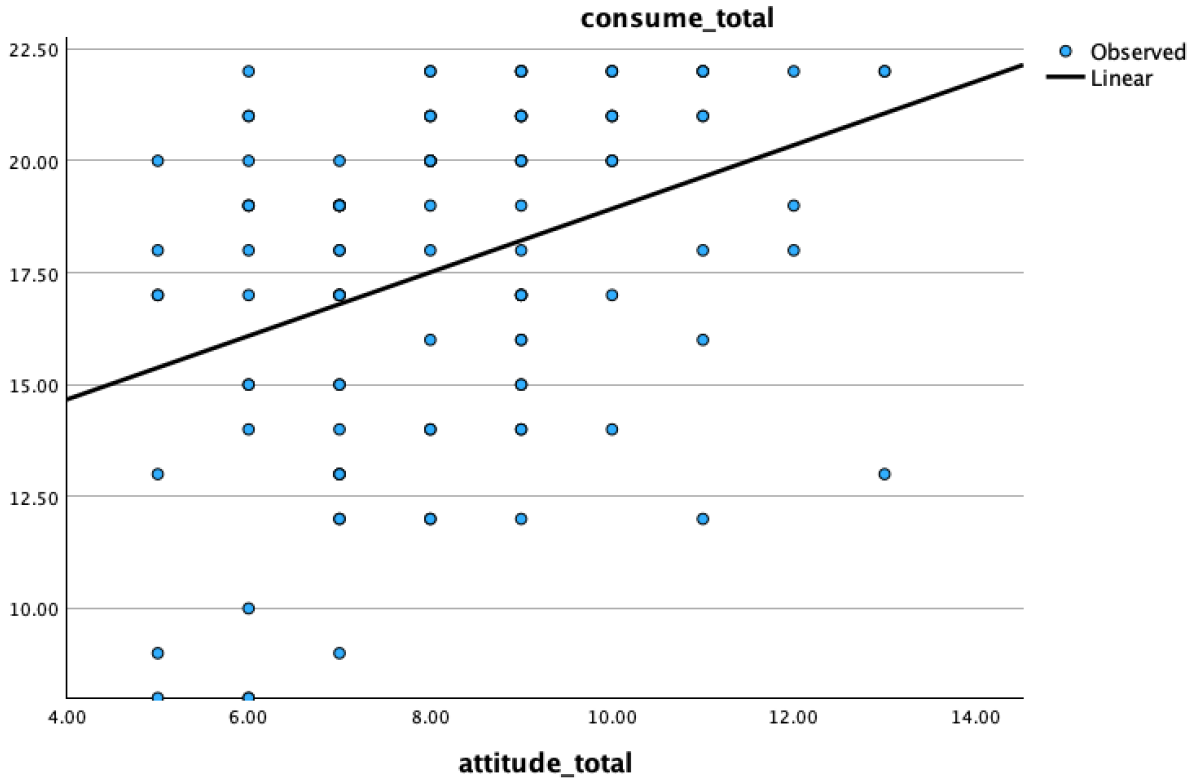


Figure 8: Scatter Plot Graph of Attitude toward Social Media Promotions and Consumption Behavior

We found a moderate positive correlation between attitude toward social media promotions and consumption behavior, r (110) = .368, p < .001 (Figure 6). There is a strong line of regression between attitude and consumption behavior, R^2 = .136, F(1, 109) = 16.941, p < .001, which suggests that 13.6% of the variation in consumption behavior comes from attitudes toward social media promotions (Figure 7). The scatterplot graph of consumption behavior vs. attitude toward social media promotions with the line of regression has a coefficient = .710, which means that when there is an increase in positive attitude on TikTok, it will result in a relatively similar amount of increase in the consumption behavior (Figure 8).

H3: TikTok users with high screen time will be shown more advertisements/promotions than those with lower screen time.

Descriptive Statistics

	Mean	Std. Deviation	N
time_total	6.7414	2.04778	116
num_total	7.3402	2.16452	97

Correlations

		time_total	num_total
time_total	Pearson Correlation	1	.290**
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.004
	Sum of Squares and Cross-products	482.241	122.804
	Covariance	4.193	1.279
	N	116	97
num_total	Pearson Correlation	.290**	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.004	
	Sum of Squares and Cross-products	122.804	449.773
	Covariance	1.279	4.685
	N	97	97

**. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Figure 9: Pearson's r Correlation of Screen Time and Number of Advertisements

Model Summary

R	R Square	Adjusted R Square	Std. Error of the Estimate
.290	.084	.075	2.082

The independent variable is time_total.

ANOVA

	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Regression	37.903	1	37.903	8.743	.004
Residual	411.870	95	4.335		
Total	449.773	96			

The independent variable is time_total.

Coefficients

	Unstandardized Coefficients		Standardized Coefficients		
	B	Std. Error	Beta	t	Sig.
time_total	.309	.104	.290	2.957	.004
(Constant)	5.243	.740		7.085	<.001

Figure 10: Linear Regression of Screen Time and Number of Advertisements

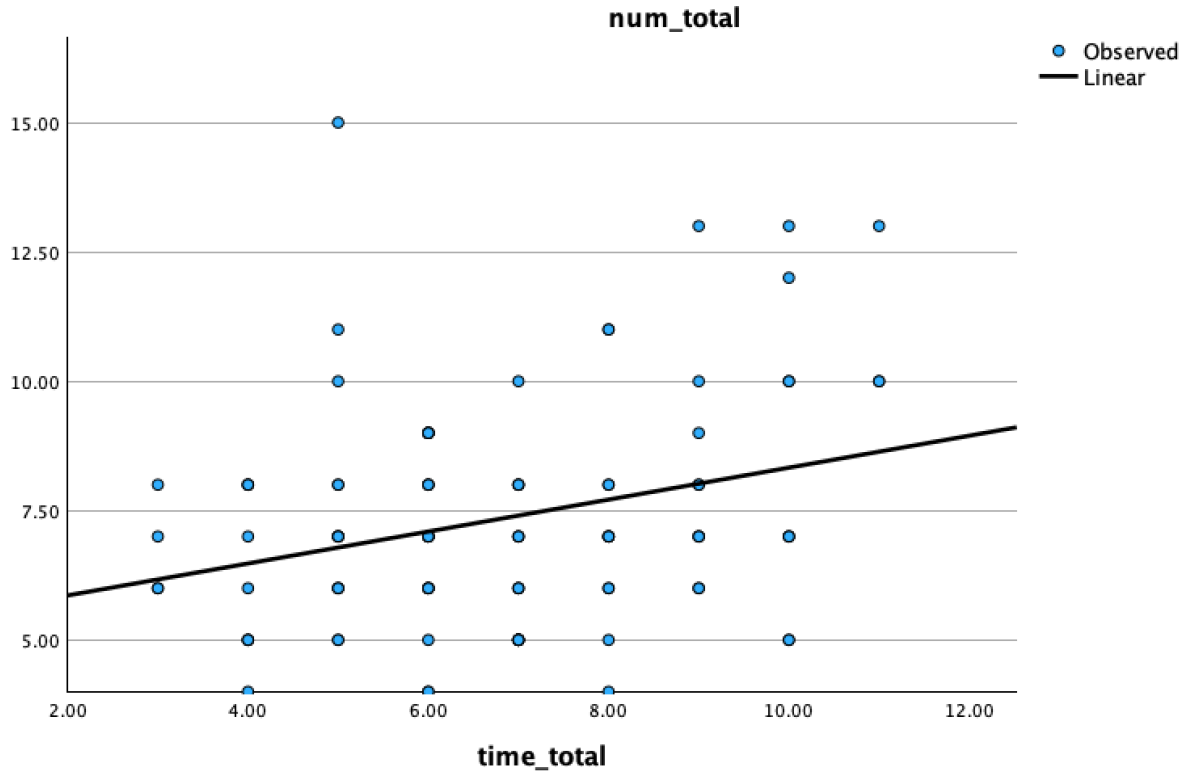


Figure 11: Scatter Plot Graph of Screen Time and Number of Advertisements

We found a small positive correlation between screen time on TikTok and number of advertisements seen, r (97) = .290, p = .004 (Figure 9). There is a strong line of regression between screen time and number of advertisements, R^2 = .084, F(1, 96) = 8.743, p = .004, which suggests 8.4% of the variation in number of advertisements comes from screen time (Figure 10). The scatterplot graph of number of advertisements vs. screen time with the line of regression has a coefficient = .309, which means that when there is an increase in screen time on TikTok, it will result in a relatively small increase in the number of advertisements (Figure 11).

Conclusion

Our test results demonstrate support for all three of our hypotheses. There is a statistically significant and moderate positive correlation between screen time and consumption behavior. The regression analysis suggests that about 22.5% of the variation in consumption behavior can be explained by screen time. The coefficient associated with the line of regression in the scatterplot further supports the idea that the increase in screen time leads to a similar amount of increase in consumption behavior. The implications of our results mean that people tend to demonstrate higher consumption behaviors when their TikTok screen time is higher. When screen time is higher, a user's feed will be more personalized to themselves. Pellegrino analyzed that users often embody herd behavior to make consumption choices based on influencers who are often viewed as idealized versions of themselves or when their attitudes toward social media promotions are more positive.

There is also a statistically significant and moderate positive correlation between consumers' attitudes toward social media promotions and their consumption behavior. The regression analysis suggests that about 13.6% of the variation in consumption behavior can be explained by attitude. The coefficient associated with the line of regression in the scatterplot further supports the idea that the increase in positive attitude leads to a similar amount of increase in consumption behavior. This supports our hypothesis, which suggests TikTok users with higher positive attitudes toward social media promotions exhibit higher consumption behaviors. Furthermore, consumer perception of social media advertising, viral marketing, and brand awareness positively impact purchase intent (Vianna et al., 2016). Our evidence paired with other studies, shows consumers' attitude toward social media promotions affects their consumption behavior.

Lastly, there is a statistically significant but small positive correlation between screen time on TikTok and the number of advertisements seen. The regression analysis suggests that about 8.4% of the variation in the number of advertisements can be explained by screen time. The coefficient associated with the line of regression in the scatterplot further supports the idea that the increase in screen time leads to a relatively small increase in the number of advertisements. This supports our hypothesis, which suggests TikTok users with high screen time are shown more advertisements/promotions than those with lower screen time. TikTok has become a mainstream platform for short-form video commerce which is used for advertisements. The engagement rate of TikTok is 5.7%, which is 12 times more than Instagram (Lauron, 2023). Therefore, if there is a higher engagement rate on TikTok, users have a higher screen time. That means more advertisements are seen as TikTok with the increase of social media-based marketing.

For companies that aim to promote their products on TikTok, it would be more effective to target TikTok users with high screen time, as well as to create high-quality advertisements that can evoke favorable reactions from consumers. For individuals who would like to change their purchasing behaviors on TikTok, it would be beneficial for them to control the amount of time spent on TikTok.

Some confounding variables for this experiment could be economic status and job circumstances. Economic status could be a confounding variable because those who have more disposable income to spend on themselves could be more likely to spend money on TikTok. To address this variable, a question could be asked about people's estimated disposable income. If further standardization is wanted, we could target a specific group of people with the same amount of disposable income and see the variation of answers from that group. Job

circumstances regarding working remotely vs. in-person could be a confounding variable because those who have more access to their phone, presumably remote, have higher screen time. To address this, we can ask people if they work remotely or in person and separate results into groups to compare later on.

Our research was limited by the amount of people we were able to survey. We believe having a larger scale outside of Boston could lead to greater insights and implications. Moreover, for our section regarding the number of advertisements/promotions, we asked participants to number the amount of ads they got as they scrolled through five videos on their for you page. We explicitly asked for videos that were being advertised as sponsored. Some people may have missed a video or been unable to properly distinguish an advertisement from a regular video. With more time and funding, monitorization could be helpful. Also, making people scroll through their feed page for more than five videos may yield more accurate results.

If new research were to be conducted, other social media platforms could be researched to see whether results vary or remain similar to what was observed with TikTok. It may also be interesting to investigate if results vary from different countries because of different regulatory laws regarding advertisements on social media. Lastly, undisclosed ads could be researched, as we told participants to explicitly think of advertisements and promotions, but a lot of TikTok videos have undisclosed ads which may affect results.

Works Cited

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